Israel attacks first it will be accused of aggression, not only by the Arab states, but by the entire world. Israeli governments have always attached supreme importance to the world's perception of it—in the West in general, and in the United States in particular—as a country whose wars are forced upon it and who goes to war only to defend itself against aggressors.

The prestate military doctrine was a hybrid; that is, it was varied and not entirely coherent. The pre-independence Jewish community, the Yishuv, lived in very difficult conditions: the two populations, the Jews and the Arabs, mingled on the same territory. The number of Palestinian Arabs far exceeded the number of Jews. The Palestinian Arabs had unlimited strategic backing in the form of the entire Middle East, full of Arab states, all of which had regular armies.

The Jewish military response took the form of secret militias operating under the British Mandate. These militias arose and operated in a political environment in which the political parties were preparing themselves for the struggle for power in the future independent state to be established upon the end of the British Mandate. The largest and most important of these militias was the Haganah, which was subordinate to the Jewish Agency for Palestine and controlled by the Labor parties (Mapai and Mapam). The Haganah established and operated a body that was similar to Military Intelligence in its organization and objectives—the Information Service ("Shai"). The Shai included a network of regional controllers who operated Arabicspeaking officers recruiting agents from among the Arab population for HUMINT (human intelligence)—the only intelligence discipline at the time. Here and there one could also see the very modest beginnings of intelligence gathered from listening in on communications. The intelligence product was the "village files," which contained all of the intelligence needed for military or diplomatic action. The other militias—Etzel and Lehi—made do with the collection of specific intelligence for planned operations, mainly against the Mandate authorities.

Five Arab states—Egypt, Jordan, Lebanon, Syria, and Iraq—sent armies to destroy the State of Israel immediately after its declaration of independence. The number of casualties of the War of Independence is estimated at about six thousand, that is, one percent of the Jewish population. The war ended with armistice agreements, not with peace agreements. The IDF was created over the course of the war and came out of it battered. The period immediately following the war was a formative one